offensive operations, the pilots scrupulously adhered to the political directive.[53]

India's extraordinary military restraint in this crisis constitutes an important puzzle. To begin with, the country's intelligence and security apparatus had been found seriously wanting.[54] More to the point, the principal political party in the ruling coalition, the Bharatiya Janata Party, was known for its bellicose views about Pakistan and its willingness to use force to settle international disputes. Despite its intransigence toward Pakistan, it had, in an effort to assuage global concerns about regional stability, undertaken a bold effort to try and reduce bilateral tensions a few months before the onset of the Kargil crisis.

Specifically, in February 1999, Prime Minister Atal Behari Vajpayee had opened a bus service linking the cities of Amritsar and Lahore and had traveled to Pakistan to work toward a possible Indo-Pakistan rapprochement. In considerable part, this gesture had been undertaken to assuage concerns on the part of the global community and to show that despite the nuclear tests, South Asia did not constitute a nuclear flashpoint.[55] His overture, at least notionally, had yielded significant results in the form of the Lahore Declaration. This statement called for a series of confidence-building measures and reaffirmed the stated resolve of both sides to seek a peaceful resolution of the Kashmir dispute.

Given that the Kargil incursions took place within three months of the Lahore Summit there was a profound sense of betrayal in New Delhi. Not surprisingly, passions ran high against the regime of Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif. An oncoming national election within a matter of months also placed substantial pressure on the BJP-led government in New Delhi to respond with decisiveness to the Pakistani incursions.

Despite the hostility of the BJP toward Pakistan, its profound sense of betrayal about the Lahore peace process, the significant reserve forces at hand, and electoral pressures, the regime kept the entire conflict limited in scope and dimensions. It refused to open a second front to alleviate pressures in Kashmir; it instructed the IAF not to carry out sorties across the line of control; and it sought to terminate the conflict as soon as the last intruders had been evicted